

The purpose of a policy brief is to both inform and persuade an audience. To write effectively, you must understand your audience and tailor your writing to their needs.

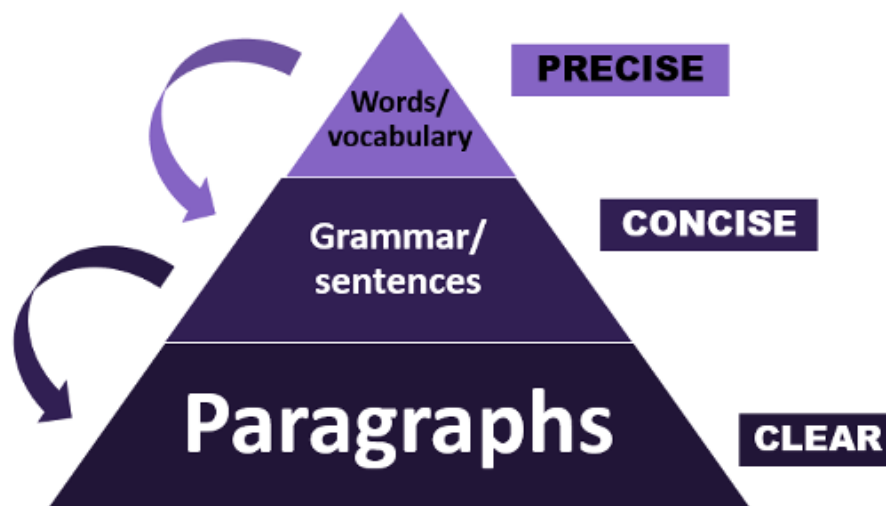
Know your audience

Your audience consists of the people who you hope will read your brief and act on its recommendations.

- **Understand your audience by asking:**
 - Who are they? What is their background and what are their interests?
 - What do they already know about the topic, and what do they need to know?
 - What do you want them to do with the information, and what is the best way to motivate them?
- **Tailor your brief to the needs of your audience by:**
 - Addressing their interests and concerns;
 - Connecting with them at their level;
 - Respecting their time with concise writing and a brief document.

Tips for effective writing

Effective writing starts with a **well-organized document**. Your policy brief should have **clear sections with headings**, and a **logical flow**. A well-written brief uses precise words, concise sentences and clear paragraphs. Be sure to carefully proofread your document to catch any errors before you share it.



Precise words:

- Use simple language;
- Avoid unfamiliar jargon and acronyms;
- Use consistent terminology;
- Use inclusive words.

Concise grammar/sentences:

- Be succinct, using only the words you need to make your point;
- Communicate one main idea per sentence;
- Vary sentence length, but avoid very long sentences;
- Use bullets with parallel structure for lists;
- Use active rather than passive voice
("Residents investigated the outbreak," not "The outbreak was investigated by the residents").

Clear paragraphs:

- Start with a topic sentence that indicates the focus of the paragraph.
- Present information with a logical and consistent pattern, such as:
 - Announced order
 - Most to least important
 - Chronological order
 - Pros and cons
 - Problem and solution
 - Funnel (broad to narrow focus)
- Conclude the paragraph by summarizing the information, drawing a conclusion, or highlighting an important point.